

AFRICAN HUMANITARIAN AGENCY

Foundational Operational Framework 1

Continental Humanitarian Coordination and Partnership Framework

1. Purpose

This framework establishes how the African Humanitarian Agency will coordinate humanitarian action and build operational partnerships at continental, regional and national levels. Its purpose is to define AfHA's place within Africa's humanitarian architecture, clarify roles and relationships with Member States, Regional Economic Communities, African Union organs and specialised agencies, and provide a structured basis for engagement with international partners, local actors and affected communities.

The framework is intended to ensure that AfHA adds value through coordination, complementarity and African leadership, rather than duplication. It therefore sets out the principles, structures, partnership modalities and decision pathways through which AfHA will convene, align and support action before, during and after humanitarian crises.

AfHA is a Specialised Technical Institution of the AUC and the operational arm of the African Union Department of Health, Humanitarian Affairs and Social Development (AUHHS). The Department holds the political, normative and policy mandate, while AfHA performs the operational coordination functions, and where required the operational delivery functions, that the Commission cannot perform by design. This framework therefore positions AfHA as an operational coordinator. Its primary contribution is to convene, align and strengthen the institutions already present in Africa's humanitarian space, but it also carries defined operational functions, set out in section 4, that extend beyond convening. The framework does not make AfHA a parallel implementing agency, and it does not transfer policy authority from the Department to AfHA.

2. Rationale

Africa's humanitarian landscape is institutionally dense but operationally uneven. Member States retain primary responsibility for humanitarian action within their territories. At the same time, Regional Economic Communities (RECs), AU departments and specialised agencies, humanitarian partners, civil society organisations and local responders all perform important roles. In practice, however, these roles are not always coherently connected. Coordination often remains ad hoc, reactive, event specific, or driven by external systems and funding incentives.

AfHA is being established precisely to address this fragmentation. Its statutory functions include collaboration with different levels of authority and humanitarian actors to identify and map humanitarian crises, provide strong coordination mechanisms on humanitarian issues, develop partnerships and coordinate relations with Member States, RECs, early warning institutions, the African Standby Force, Africa CDC, local communities, affected populations and international partners, and elevate the visibility of the AU in alleviating suffering on the continent. This framework provides the operational architecture through which those statutory functions can be implemented in a clear, disciplined and feasible way.

In designing its coordination and partnership arrangements, AfHA draws deliberately on the accumulated practice of comparable regional and continental humanitarian coordination mechanisms elsewhere in the world. That experience points consistently to a small number of design choices that distinguish mechanisms which add durable value from those that remain declaratory. These include a single, always-on operational coordination hub rather than ad hoc disaster structures; a request-based activation logic anchored in the affected state; pre-agreed standby arrangements and rosters rather than improvised mobilisation; pooled and pre-positioned capacities that can be released when national capacity is overwhelmed; a graduated and certified response and assessment team model; a tiered and predictable set of information products; and a disciplined single entry point for external assistance. This framework incorporates these practices, adapted to African institutional realities and to AfHA's Statute, without importing the governance model of any single external body.

3. Objectives

This framework pursues the following objectives:

- Define AfHA's coordination role across continental, regional, national and local levels.
- Clarify the principles of subsidiarity, complementarity and Member State primacy.
- Establish partnership categories and engagement modalities for different actor groups.
- Provide structures and protocols for routine coordination, preparedness coordination and disaster coordination.
- Define the interface between AfHA and the global humanitarian system.
- Strengthen African ownership while preserving openness to strategic external support.
- Support consistent engagement with local actors, affected populations and regional institutions.
- Create a basis for related SOPs on coordination activation, information sharing, partner engagement, liaison and joint planning.
- Strengthen coordination of early warning, preparedness and response systems across all levels.
- Enhance capacity of Member States, RECs and partners to manage humanitarian crises
- Improve information sharing, data management and situational awareness
- Promote coordinated resource mobilisation and efficient use of available capacities
- Ensure accountability, transparency and performance monitoring of coordination efforts.

4. Scope

This section defines the institutional, functional, hazard-type, temporal, geographic and phased scope of the framework, and sets out the complementarity test that governs any expansion of AfHA's role.

4.1 Institutional scope

This framework applies to AfHA's relationships with the following actors:

- AU policy organs and the AU Commission
- Member States and designated national focal institutions
- Regional Economic Communities and Regional Mechanisms
- AfHA Regional Centres
- Africa CDC, AMHEWAS and other relevant AU and continental systems
- African Standby Force and related peace and security structures where appropriate
- AU Peace and Security Council (PSC) and its subsidiary organs, in respect of the humanitarian dimensions of conflict situations
- Humanitarian partners
- International and African non-governmental organisations
- Civil society organisations, community-based organisations and local responders
- Research, academic and technical institutions
- Development partners, donors and private sector actors where relevant to humanitarian coordination
- Women's, youth and child-focused organisations and networks
- Affected populations and their representative structures
- Coordinating Committee on Forced Displacement and Humanitarian Action
- African Migration Observatory and other AU data and research entities
- Regional humanitarian and disaster (risk) management networks.

4.2 Functional scope and limits

Within the institutional relationships above, AfHA performs coordination functions and a defined set of operational functions. Its coordination functions include continental convening, operational alignment, linking early warning to early action, serving as the partner interface for actors engaging at continental or multi-country level, and strengthening national and regional coordination systems. Its operational functions are confined to those that Member States and RECs cannot perform alone,

principally surge and logistics support, multi-country and cross-border operational coordination, support to anticipatory action, and the facilitation of humanitarian access.

To keep the mandate disciplined and to avoid the progressive expansion observed in comparable institutions, the framework also states what AfHA does not do. AfHA does not replace Member State leadership or national coordination architecture. It does not substitute for the in-country coordination arrangements of the humanitarian partners. It does not become a standing implementing agency delivering assistance in place of operational partners. It does not duplicate functioning REC, African Union or partner mechanisms. Any function not expressly within scope, and any new structure, must pass the complementarity test in section 4.6 before it is assumed.

4.3 Hazard/disaster/crisis scope, including armed conflict

This framework applies across the full range of crises that generate humanitarian need in Africa. These include rapid- and slow-onset natural hazards, climate-related and environmental crises, public health emergencies, food insecurity, and crises of displacement, including the humanitarian border-management dimensions of cross-border movement. The framework also applies to humanitarian crises caused by armed conflict, which drive the greater part of humanitarian need on the continent and cannot be excluded from a continental humanitarian mandate.

AfHA's engagement in conflict settings is differentiated. Assistance activities, such as the coordination of food, shelter, water and cash support, fall squarely within scope. Protection activities and advocacy for international humanitarian law (IHL) are more sensitive, because they depend on the perception of the responding institution as neutral, independent and impartial. In conflict settings AfHA will therefore lead on assistance coordination and access facilitation, engage on protection in a manner that does not compromise the neutral, independent and impartial humanitarian action (NIHA) of specialised protection actors, and route the political dimensions of conflict response through the interface with the AU Peace and Security Council described in section 7.7. The operational detail of this differentiation is set out in the relevant standard operating procedures (SOPs).

4.4 Temporal and geographic scope

This framework applies across the full scope of disaster risk reduction, disaster response and across all levels of the African humanitarian architecture. It applies in routine periods, preparedness periods, anticipatory action contexts and active emergencies, and also across the continental, regional, national and local levels defined in section 8, with AfHA's role at each level calibrated to subsidiarity and Member State primacy.

4.5 Phased scope

AfHA's scope is exercised progressively rather than in full at inception. Recognising the financing, capacity and political constraints identified during consultation, the framework provides for managed ambition. In its first phase AfHA will concentrate on a core set of coordination functions, working through existing African Union field presences and Regional Centres rather than establishing parallel structures. Functional, geographic and operational scope will expand in later phases only as capacity, predictable financing and demonstrated value allow. Each foundational framework and SOP carries a phased implementation logic consistent with this provision.

4.6 Complementarity test

Before AfHA assumes any function or establishes any structure under this framework, it will apply a complementarity test. The test requires a documented mapping of existing Member State, REC, African Union and partner capacities relevant to the function in question, an assessment of whether an effective mechanism already exists, and a justification of the specific value AfHA would add. Where an effective mechanism already exists, AfHA connects to and strengthens it rather than duplicating it. The complementarity test is the principal safeguard against duplication and mandate creep, and it applies in routine, preparedness and disaster conditions alike.

This framework defines AfHA's coordination and partnership architecture. It does not provide the detailed operating model for financing, information management, capacity development, surge readiness, preparedness, anticipatory action or advocacy. Those functions are governed by the companion foundational frameworks. Where this framework refers to these functions, it does so to define the coordination interface, escalation pathway or partnership relationship.

5. Normative basis

This framework is grounded in the following instruments, relationships and principles:

- The Statute of the African Humanitarian Agency
- Relevant AU humanitarian, DRR, displacement, peace and security, health and climate instruments
- Cooperation with Member States through designated national institutions
- Coordination with global humanitarian system and partners
- The principles of humanity, impartiality, independence, neutrality, solidarity, accountability, participation and ownership, subsidiarity and complementarity, and non-interference
- Existing AU and REC institutional arrangements and coordination obligations
- AfHA's foundational operational frameworks, particularly the Institutional Operational Agility Framework, the Humanitarian Data and Information Interoperability Framework, the Capacity Development and Surge Readiness Framework, and the Preparedness, Anticipatory Action, and Risk Reduction Framework.

6. Guiding principles for coordination and partnership

AfHA's coordination and partnership arrangements are governed by seven guiding principles. These principles apply in routine, preparedness and disaster conditions alike, and they inform the interpretation of every subsequent section of this framework.

6.1 Member State primacy

Member States retain primary responsibility for the protection and assistance of their populations and for leading humanitarian action in their territories. AfHA will support, reinforce and complement national leadership, not replace it.

6.2 Subsidiarity

Action should be taken at the most appropriate level closest to the point of need. National systems lead where they can. Regional systems add value where issues are transboundary or where regional solidarity and pooled capability are needed. Continental coordination supports coherence, mobilisation, visibility and cross regional consistency.

6.3 Complementarity

AfHA will not duplicate mandates or capacities that already exist and function effectively. Instead, it will connect, strengthen, convene and, where necessary, fill coordination gaps.

6.4 African ownership

The framework is explicitly designed to strengthen African institutions, African solutions and African legitimacy in humanitarian action, while remaining open to strategic support from the global system.

6.5 Inclusivity

Coordination must include not only high level institutions but also local responders, community based structures, women's organisations, youth groups, technical experts and affected populations where feasible.

6.6 Predictability

Coordination arrangements should be known before crises occur. Roles, contact points, meeting rhythms, reporting channels and liaison protocols should be pre agreed.

6.7 Accountability

Partnerships and coordination must be transparent, documented and reviewable. Coordination is not merely convening meetings. It must produce decisions, tasking, shared understanding and measurable value.

7. AfHA's coordination role

AfHA's role is best understood as six linked functions.

7.1 Continental convening

AfHA will provide a continental platform for strategic humanitarian coordination, connecting AU organs, RECs, Member States and key partners. This includes regular forums, disaster consultations and strategic review processes.

7.2 Operational alignment

AfHA will help align operating tempo, response priorities, surge support, logistics, financing and external engagement across institutions, especially where crises span borders or require regional solidarity.

7.3 Link between warning and action

AfHA will connect early warning and risk information to coordination decisions, anticipatory action and response readiness across actors and levels.

7.4 Partner interface

AfHA will serve as an African entry point and coordination interlocutor for external humanitarian actors that wish to engage at continental or multi-country level.

7.5 Visibility and political support

AfHA will elevate the visibility of African humanitarian action and facilitate strategic engagement with AU political structures when humanitarian operations require political support or access facilitation.

7.6 Systems strengthening

AfHA will support stronger and more consistent national and regional coordination capacities through tools, guidance, training and practice.

7.7 Engagement in conflict-affected settings

Armed conflict drives the majority of humanitarian need in Africa, therefore AfHA's coordination role extends into conflict-affected settings, within the differentiated scope set out in section 4.3. In these settings, AfHA coordinates assistance and facilitates humanitarian access, while taking care that its engagement does not compromise the neutral, independent and impartial humanitarian action of dedicated protection actors such as the International Committee of the Red Cross.

AfHA maintains a defined interface with the AU Peace and Security Council (PSC). This interface serves as the channel for the political and access dimensions of conflict response, so that humanitarian coordination is supported by, but kept distinct from, political and security decision-making. In conflict contexts, AfHA's engagement may proceed on a notification basis where request-based national leadership of an impartial response is absent, consistent with the Statute and applicable international law.

7.8 Single operational entry point

AfHA provides a single, recognisable continental entry point through which offers of assistance, requests for support, and partner engagement at the continental or multi-country level are received, registered, and routed. A single entry point reduces the confusion, duplication and competitive

mobilisation that arise when multiple channels operate in parallel during a disaster or when a situation threatens to become disastrous. The entry point does not centralise decision-making, which remains with the affected Member State and the relevant REC, but it does ensure that every offer and request is visible, tracked and directed to the appropriate level. The operational detail of the single entry point sits in the coordination activation SOP.

8. Levels of coordination

AfHA coordinates across four levels: continental, regional, national and local. The paragraphs below define the concern of each level and the key functions AfHA performs there. The design principle across all four levels is that the higher tier enables the lower tier rather than absorbing functions that belong closer to the point of need.

8.1 Continental level

The continental level is concerned with strategic coherence, cross-regional analysis, policy alignment, external positioning, continental financing, AU level visibility and support to major multi-country crises. At this level AfHA must guard against mandate creep, so that the continental tier enables regional and national action rather than absorbing operational functions that belong at lower levels.

Key AfHA functions at this level include the following:

- convene continental humanitarian coordination meetings
- maintain a continental common operating picture
- coordinate with AU organs and specialised agencies
- engage with international partners on cross-regional and continent wide issues
- provide strategic direction to Regional Centres
- support mobilisation of continental resources
- support implementation of AU policy guidance and decisions on humanitarian action
- strengthen coordination of early warning, preparedness, and response systems
- facilitate collaboration with RECs, Member States, and partners at continental scale
- promote data, research, and knowledge sharing on humanitarian crises
- enhance AU visibility and strategic advocacy on humanitarian issues.

8.2 Regional level

The regional level is the operational bridge between national realities and continental strategy. It is especially important for transboundary crises, regional preparedness, shared risk analysis and surge support.

Key functions at this level include the following:

- support REC-linked coordination structures
- facilitate cross-border planning and information exchange
- host or support regional coordination cells during activation
- coordinate regional surge and logistics support
- relay regional priorities to the AUC
- support implementation of regional preparedness and response plans
- strengthen coordination of early warning, risk analysis and anticipatory action at regional level
- facilitate regional capacity building and training for Member States
- support harmonisation of regional policies and procedures for disaster response
- promote information sharing and interoperability among neighbouring countries.

8.3 National level

At national level AfHA does not replace government coordination or the humanitarian country architecture already in place. Instead, it supports and complements national leadership where

requested, especially when continental or regional value add is needed. In conflict-affected national contexts where a Member State is unable or unwilling to lead an impartial response, AfHA's modality shifts from request-based support to notification-based facilitation, exercised through the conflict-engagement provisions in section 7.7 and the PSC interface.

Key functions at this level include the following:

- work through designated national focal institutions
- support national coordination with regional and continental systems
- help align anticipatory action and surge support
- facilitate access to continental expertise, funding windows and visibility
- provide support in cross-border or exceptional crises
- support capacity strengthening of national coordination mechanisms
- facilitate integration of national data into continental information systems
- support national risk analysis and early warning and early action systems
- assist in aligning national preparedness and contingency plans
- facilitate coordination with international and regional partners at country level
- support mobilisation of technical and surge support at national level
- contribute to national situation reporting and information flows
- support coordination of humanitarian access where needed
- promote inclusion of local actors and community-based structures
- assist in identifying gaps in national response capacity
- support national participation in regional and continental coordination forums.

8.4 Local level

AfHA's direct presence at local level will usually be limited. However, its coordination model must ensure that local actors are not bypassed.

Key functions at this level include the following:

- promote local actor inclusion through national and regional partners
- encourage use of local knowledge in assessments and planning
- strengthen downward information flows and accountability
- ensure local responders are reflected in surge, training and planning systems
- support engagement with local authorities and community structures
- facilitate two-way communication with affected populations
- promote community-based early warning and risk monitoring
- support local-level data collection and information sharing
- strengthen links between local responders and national focal institutions
- support inclusion of vulnerable groups, including women, youth and displaced populations
- promote localisation and use of national and local capacities
- support coordination of local preparedness and response planning
- facilitate feedback and complaints mechanisms at community level
- support awareness-raising and risk communication with communities.

9. Core coordination structures

AfHA operationalises its coordination role through a small set of standing and activated structures. These are the African Humanitarian Coordination Platform, the Regional Coordination Forums, the Disaster Management Cells, the National Liaison Arrangements, and, underpinning all of them, a standing continental coordination hub described in section 9.5. Each structure has a defined membership, function and rhythm, so that coordination arrangements are known before crises occur rather than improvised during them.

9.1 African Humanitarian Coordination Platform

AfHA must have a seat on the African Humanitarian Coordination Platform linked to the AU system. The Platform is the continental forum through which the AUC convenes actors, aligns coordination priorities and routes issues to the relevant companion frameworks without duplicating their technical provisions.

The functions of the Platform are to:

- (include from TOR – ask Tsegaye)

9.2 Regional Coordination Forums

Each AfHA Regional Centre should support, identify or co-convene a Regional Coordination Forum, preferably anchored in existing REC structures. The forum provides the regional coordination space through which national focal points, REC mechanisms, AfHA Headquarters and partners align action, escalate constraints and maintain readiness visibility.

The functions of each Regional Coordination Forum are to:

- maintain regional contact, liaison and coordination readiness
- review cross-border and multi-country risks requiring regional attention
- connect national focal points to AfHA systems and continental coordination processes
- facilitate real-time information sharing and regional situation updates in line with the Humanitarian Data and Information Interoperability Framework (Framework 3)
- coordinate regional partner alignment and support resolution of cross-border operational constraints
- identify needs for surge, logistics or capacity support and route them through the Capacity Development and Surge Readiness Framework (Framework 4)
- support preparedness, contingency and anticipatory planning interfaces governed by the Preparedness, Anticipatory Action and Risk Reduction Framework (Framework 5)
- provide regular regional coordination updates to Headquarters.

9.3 Operational Centres

During activation, AfHA may establish an operational centre at Headquarters, in a Regional Centre, or both. These are temporary operational coordination structures.

The functions of an Operational Centre are to:

- maintain shared operating picture
- coordinate decisions and tasking
- manage partner interface
- track requests, actions and gaps
- support communications and reporting
- activate and manage disaster coordination cell structures and staffing
- establish clear coordination lines with national and regional focal points
- issue regular situation reports and operational updates
- coordinate rapid assessment and validation of field information
- prioritise and align response actions across partners
- track and resolve operational bottlenecks in real time
- coordinate deployment of surge personnel and technical support
- facilitate access, logistics and supply chain coordination
- manage escalation of access, security and policy constraints
- support real-time decision-making through coordination briefs
- maintain contact with field-level coordination structures
- coordinate messaging and information consistency across partners
- prepare briefings for senior leadership and AU structures.

9.4 National Liaison Arrangements

AfHA should work through designated national focal institutions, ideally ministries or agencies responsible for humanitarian affairs, disaster management, civil protection or equivalent functions.

Each Member State should ideally nominate the following focal points:

- one senior policy focal point
- one operational focal point
- one data and information focal point where feasible.

9.5 Continental humanitarian coordination hub

Underpinning all of the structures above, AfHA will establish and maintain a standing continental humanitarian coordination hub at its Headquarters. The hub is the always-on operational core of AfHA's coordination role. In routine periods it monitors risk and maintains readiness; in crises it becomes the operational nerve centre of the Disaster Management Cell. Comparable mechanisms elsewhere have shown that a standing, continuously staffed hub, rather than a structure that is stood up only when a disaster is already under way, is the single most important determinant of timely and coherent coordination.

The hub performs the following functions:

- maintain continuous monitoring of hazards, risks and emerging crises across the continent, drawing on continental (AMHEWAS) and regional early warning systems rather than generating early warning itself
- maintain the continental common operating picture and keep it current between and during crises
- receive, register and route requests for assistance and offers of support through the single entry point defined in section 7.8
- serve as the twenty-four hour point of contact for Member States, Regional Economic Communities and partners during activation
- track the status of standby capacities, rosters and pre-positioned stocks and their readiness for deployment
- produce and disseminate the tiered coordination information products defined in section 13
- support the transition from monitoring to activation by triggering pre-agreed notification and readiness procedures when thresholds are approached.

The hub is established progressively in line with the phased scope in section 4.5. In its first phase it may operate with limited staffing and extended-hours rather than full continuous coverage, working through existing African Union presences, and it expands toward continuous coverage as capacity and predictable financing allow. The operational detail of the hub sits in the coordination activation SOP.

10. Partnership architecture

AfHA will work with five broad categories of partners, each with distinct modalities.

Across all partnership categories, AfHA applies a predictable partner engagement standard: partners are mapped and registered before crises, engagement terms are documented, and the basis of each relationship is transparent. This standard mirrors the disciplined partner accreditation and engagement practice of mature coordination mechanisms elsewhere, in which the quality and predictability of partnership arrangements are treated as an operational asset rather than an administrative formality.

Partnership categories in this section define how AfHA relates to different actor groups. They do not replace the technical provisions of the financing, information, capacity, preparedness or advocacy frameworks. Detailed standards, procedures and tools for those areas are governed by the relevant companion framework.

10.1 Strategic governance and policy partners

These include AU policy organs, the AU Commission, relevant specialised technical committees, and other AU specialised institutions.

Relationship type includes the following:

- formal institutional coordination
- policy alignment
- reporting and mutual support
- strategic decision support

Key modalities include the following:

- formal reporting
- policy briefings
- joint work planning
- standing representation in coordination forums

10.2 Regional and national institutional partners

These include RECs, Regional Mechanisms, national disaster management authorities, civil protection institutions and relevant line ministries.

Relationship type includes the following:

- operational coordination and joint planning
- mutual notification, liaison and readiness visibility
- coordination of cross-border preparedness and response arrangements
- data exchange and information sharing, governed technically by the Humanitarian Data and Information Interoperability Framework (Framework 3)
- identification of surge, logistics and capacity needs, governed operationally by the Capacity Development and Surge Readiness Framework (Framework 4)
- alignment with preparedness and anticipatory action processes governed by the Preparedness, Anticipatory Action and Risk Reduction Framework (Framework 5)
- coordinated advocacy and resource mobilisation interfaces, governed by the Humanitarian Financing and Resource Mobilisation Framework (Frameworks 2) and the Political Advocacy and Visibility Framework (Framework 6) where relevant.

Key modalities include the following:

- MoUs or operational cooperation arrangements
- focal point systems and liaison officer arrangements
- shared planning calendars and coordination protocols
- regional and national coordination forums
- standard operating procedures for joint coordination
- joint review processes that feed lessons into Framework 4 and Framework 5 mechanisms

10.3 Humanitarian operational partners

These include humanitarian partners, civil society organisations and local responders.

Relationship type includes the following:

- operational complementarity and field coordination
- information exchange and shared situational awareness, governed technically by Framework 3
- coordinated assessment, prioritisation and response alignment
- access facilitation and referral coordination where appropriate
- localisation, community engagement and accountability-to-affected-populations interfaces
- surge, training and capability support only through the systems governed by Framework 4.

Key modalities include the following:

- partnership guidelines
- disaster-specific coordination arrangements
- liaison officers and partner coordination platforms
- joint assessments where appropriate
- partner maps and capability registers maintained for coordination visibility
- information-sharing protocols and data exchange mechanisms aligned to Framework 3.

10.4 Technical and knowledge partners

These include universities, research institutions, climate and risk centres, public health institutes, training centres and specialist AU agencies/institutions.

Relationship type includes the following:

- knowledge support
- analytics
- tools and systems development
- learning and evaluation
- innovation
- training and capacity development programmes
- research partnerships and knowledge sharing platforms.

Key modalities include the following:

- technical cooperation agreements
- communities of practice
- secondments and fellowship arrangements
- co production of guidance and analysis
- joint research and innovation initiatives
- technical advisory support during crises.

10.5 Resource and enabling partners

These include donors, development finance institutions, philanthropic actors and relevant private sector entities.

Framework 1 defines the coordination interface with these partners. The governance of financing streams, pooled funds, in-kind support, emergency contingency resources, surge financing, anticipatory financing, reporting and fiduciary accountability is governed by Framework 2.

Relationship type includes the following:

- coordination of partner engagement and strategic briefings
- alignment of support with AfHA priorities and coordination requirements
- routing of financing, in-kind and enabling support through the mechanisms governed by Framework 2
- linking resource mobilisation messages to the advocacy and visibility processes governed by Framework 6.

Key modalities include the following:

- funding or cooperation agreements aligned to AfHA systems
- participation in strategic briefings and coordination forums where appropriate
- registration of non-financial contributions for coordination visibility
- joint monitoring, reporting and accountability arrangements as specified in Framework 2.

10.6 Standby arrangements and pooled capacities

AfHA's coordination architecture must maintain visibility of standby arrangements and pooled capacities that may be requested when national or regional capacity is overwhelmed. This

Framework defines the coordination interface for identifying needs, routing requests and ensuring that such support complements Member State and REC systems. The technical design, readiness standards, certification, roster management, deployment procedures and duty-of-care arrangements for surge and standby capacities are governed by Framework 4. Financing, cost-sharing, in-kind support and contingency draw-down arrangements are governed by Framework 2. These arrangements operate on a request basis, remain subject to the complementarity test in section 4.6, and do not displace national or regional stocks, teams or coordination structures.

10.7 Deployable response and assessment roster

AfHA's coordination architecture will interface with the continental surge roster established under the Capacity Development and Surge Readiness Framework. This Framework defines when coordination structures identify a need for deployable assessment, coordination or information-management support, and how that need is routed through the appropriate request pathway. Framework 4 governs roster design, competency standards, induction, certification, readiness requirements, deployment procedures, duty of care, demobilisation and performance review. This Framework herefore does not duplicate those provisions, but ensures that roster deployment remains linked to Member State primacy, REC coordination and AfHA disaster coordination structures.

11. Coordination with key institutional actors

Building on the partnership architecture in section 10, this section sets out how AfHA coordinates with the specific institutional actors most central to its mandate. The emphasis throughout is on operational synergy and complementarity rather than institutional overlap.

11.1 Member States

AfHA will work with Member States through designated national focal institutions and request based support. Coordination with Member States should include:

- regular policy briefings
- annual or biannual readiness reviews
- agreed notification procedures
- support protocols for requests
- after action reviews following support
- support capacity building for national coordination mechanisms
- facilitate information sharing and reporting between national and continental levels
- assist in aligning national contingency and preparedness plans
- promote integration of early warning into national response systems
- support coordination with national agencies on displacement and humanitarian response.

AfHA should avoid bypassing national systems except where expressly authorised through AU processes and consistent with international law and the Statute.

11.2 Regional Economic Communities

RECs are central to AfHA's regional model. Where possible, AfHA should build on existing REC systems such as regional disaster operations centres, emergency response arrangements, climate centres and early warning structures.

Coordination with Regional Economic Communities should include the following:

- formal cooperation frameworks
- designated liaison arrangements
- shared contingency planning
- interoperability in data and reporting
- participation in regional surge and logistics arrangements
- co-convening of regional forums

- coordination of regional early warning and risk analysis systems
- support harmonisation of regional response policies and procedures
- facilitation of joint regional training and simulation exercises
- coordination of cross-border contingency planning and preparedness
- support regional resource mobilisation and partner engagement.

11.3 AU organs and specialised agencies

AfHA should maintain strong operational and strategic interfaces with AU organs and specialised agencies. The objective is not institutional overlap but operational synergy.

The relationship between AfHA and the AUHHS Department requires particular discipline. The Department exercises the political, normative and policy mandate, and AfHA exercises the operational mandate. To prevent the internal coordination friction that can arise between a parent department and an operational entity, AfHA will designate a dedicated internal liaison officer to manage the AfHA to Department interface, align work planning and reporting, and resolve mandate questions before they affect operations.

11.4 Humanitarian partners

AfHA should engage humanitarian role-players as strategic operational partners, not as a parallel system to be replaced. Key aims are to:

Key aims include the following:

- clarify complementarities
- reduce duplication
- strengthen Africa's voice in humanitarian coordination
- improve support to Member States
- facilitate continental and regional perspectives in planning
- joint planning and coordination mechanisms at regional and continental levels
- information sharing and interoperability between AfHA and humanitarian partners
- coordinated support to Member States in disaster response
- alignment of preparedness and anticipatory action frameworks
- participation in joint assessments and situation analysis
- coordination of partner engagement to avoid duplication.

Possible modalities include the following:

- framework cooperation agreements
- liaison arrangements
- participation in selected coordination forums
- joint analytical products
- agreed disaster coordination arrangements for specific contexts
- joint planning and coordination mechanisms
- information sharing and data interoperability arrangements
- secondments and staff exchange programmes
- joint training and simulation exercises
- coordinated resource mobilisation efforts.

11.5 Red Cross and Red Crescent Movement

Given its auxiliary role, reach and surge capacity, the Movement should be treated as a priority operational partner. Coordination should include:

- National Society links to national focal systems
- continental dialogue RCRC Movement components
- use of Movement surge and preparedness expertise

- joint training and simulation opportunities
- coordination of Movement response through established RCRC structures
- information sharing and joint situation analysis during crises
- support to National Society capacity strengthening and preparedness
- coordination of humanitarian access and community engagement
- alignment of Movement and AfHA response efforts to avoid duplication.

11.6 Civil society and local actors

AfHA should establish a structured but practical way to engage local actors, especially through national and regional systems. This may include:

- civil society representation in selected forums
- local actor capability mapping
- support to local responder integration into planning
- two way communication channels during crises; community feedback and complaints mechanisms
- inclusion of local actors in coordination decision-making
- support to capacity strengthening of local organisations
- engagement with women's groups, youth networks and vulnerable groups
- involvement of local actors in assessments and monitoring.

12. Coordination modalities by phase

AfHA's coordination intensity varies with the phase of a disaster. This section sets out the typical activities in each of four phases: routine, heightened readiness, active emergency, and recovery and transition. The phased logic allows AfHA to scale its engagement up and down in a predictable way, and it aligns with the graduated activation thresholds set out in the preparedness and anticipatory action framework.

12.1 Routine period

In routine periods AfHA will prioritise relationship building, planning and coordination readiness:

- establish an African Humanitarian Support Index to monitor, evaluate, and record Africa's humanitarian endeavour.
- maintain partner directories and focal point lists
- hold regular forums and coordination meetings
- review regional risks and coordination priorities
- support contingency planning interfaces with Framework 5
- maintain liaison and communication channels
- update coordination protocols and SOPs
- maintain capability visibility in coordination with the surge and capacity systems governed by Framework 4.

12.2 Heightened readiness period

When risk rises, AfHA will intensify contact and coordination:

- increase coordination calls with relevant Member States, RECs and partners
- conduct readiness reviews through the relevant coordination structures
- share pre-activation information in line with Framework 3
- identify preliminary surge, logistics and technical support needs and route them through Framework 4
- link coordination discussions to anticipatory planning and trigger processes governed by Framework 5
- initiate partner notifications and preliminary coordination arrangements.

12.3 Active emergency

When activated, AfHA will use disaster specific coordination structures and processes.

Typical activities include the following:

- daily or more frequent coordination meetings
- joint operating picture updates
- tasking and follow up matrix
- partner notifications
- issue escalation to AU structures where needed
- cross border problem solving.

12.4 Recovery and transition period

AfHA's main role in recovery is coordination, learning and linkage. Direct operational engagement in recovery is limited to the defined functions set out in section 4 and is not a general implementing role.

Typical activities include the following:

- transition planning with Member States and partners
- after action reviews
- lessons integration
- follow up support to resilience and preparedness systems
- real-time information sharing and situation reporting
- coordination of partner activities and coverage to avoid gaps
- tracking of response actions, needs and priority gaps
- facilitation of humanitarian access and operational coordination
- deployment of liaison officers or coordination support teams.

Consistent with the practice of mature coordination mechanisms elsewhere, AfHA treats recovery not as a separate phase that begins when response ends, but as a continuum in which early recovery considerations are introduced alongside response. AfHA's coordination role in this continuum is to connect response actors, recovery planning and longer-term resilience and development processes, while leaving direct operational recovery delivery to Member States, development actors and partners.

13. Information sharing for coordination

This framework depends on disciplined information sharing. The Humanitarian Data and Information Interoperability Framework governs data standards, information products, verification, protection, dashboards, minimum datasets and release protocols.

The following minimum principles apply to information sharing for coordination:

- need to share should guide information exchange
- Member State sensitivities and data ownership must be respected
- standard formats should be used wherever possible
- data should be verified before major decision use
- information products must be adapted to audience, from political brief to operational situation report
- partner contributions should be acknowledged
- sensitive protection, personal and security-related data must be handled securely.

AfHA coordination structures should use the tiered product suite, common operating picture and reporting routines established under Framework 3, rather than creating separate information products under this framework.

14. Liaison and representation

AfHA's coordination role requires disciplined liaison and representation arrangements. This section sets out how liaison officers are used and the principles that govern how AfHA represents itself and the African Union in humanitarian settings.

14.1 Liaison officers

AfHA should use liaison arrangements strategically rather than excessively. Priority liaison points may include:

- liaison with AU policy organs and the Commission for reporting and escalation
- coordination with RECs and Member States through designated focal points.

14.2 Representation principles

AfHA representatives should:

- speak from agreed mandates
- distinguish between policy positions and operational updates
- avoid undermining Member State positions
- reinforce African ownership and complementarity
- report back systematically
- ensure consistency of messaging across AU and AfHA engagements
- coordinate positions with relevant AU organs prior to representation
- respect host country protocols and diplomatic norms
- avoid duplication with other AU or partner representation
- clearly record and communicate key outcomes and follow-up actions.

15. Coordination tools

To make coordination practical, AfHA should maintain a standard coordination toolset. Tools related to data products, dashboards and reporting are governed by Framework 3, while capability, roster and readiness tools are governed by Framework 4. These can include:

- partner and focal point directory
- coordination calendar
- meeting templates and agendas
- action tracker
- contact escalation tree
- issue log
- regional and national partnership profiles
- model MoU and cooperation agreement templates
- coordination-facing capability map linked to the systems governed by Framework 4.

16. Accountability and review

Coordination effectiveness must be reviewed, not assumed. AfHA should assess:

- whether meetings produce decisions
- whether actions are tracked and completed
- whether duplication is reduced
- whether Member States perceive value
- whether partners understand AfHA's role
- whether local actors are being included meaningfully

- whether disaster coordination improves response timeliness and coherence.

Each major activation should include a coordination after-action review addressing the following:

- role clarity
- partner participation
- information flows
- bottlenecks
- political support issues
- regional and continental interface issues.

Simulation design, readiness exercises, peer-review methods and structured learning systems are governed by Framework 4. Findings from those processes should feed back into this framework where they affect coordination arrangements, role clarity or partnership modalities.

17. Risks and mitigation

This section identifies the principal risks to effective coordination and the mitigation measures AfHA will apply. The risks are presented in a summary table, followed by the specific mitigation logic for each.

Risk	Mitigation
Duplication with existing mechanisms	Build on existing REC, AU and partner platforms and use formal mapping before creating new structures.
Ambiguity over AfHA's role	Define role in formal agreements, guidance and activation protocols.
Politicisation of coordination	Adhere to statutory principles and keep humanitarian coordination distinct from political bargaining where possible.
Weak Member State buy in	Centre national focal institutions and maintain request based support logic.
External partner scepticism	Demonstrate value through disciplined coordination, clear communication and practical support.
Under inclusion of local actors	Require local actor consideration in national and regional coordination designs.
Mandate creep	Apply the complementarity test in section 4.6 before establishing any new structure or assuming any new function. Give disaster-specific structures defined lifespans and exit criteria. Review the mandate boundary annually and report any proposed expansion to the relevant AU organ.
Exclusion or politicisation of conflict-caused crises	Include conflict-caused crises within scope under section 4.3, distinguish assistance, protection and advocacy, and use the PSC interface as the political escalation channel so that humanitarian coordination remains insulated from political bargaining.

18. Implementation roadmap

The scope set out in this framework is phased. AfHA will not assume its full functional and geographic scope at inception. In the first phase it will concentrate on a limited set of coordination functions, while companion frameworks establish the detailed systems for financing, information, surge readiness, preparedness and advocacy.

Within 3 months of framework adoption

Priority actions in this window are as follows:

- approve standard partnership categories
- establish AfHA partner directory template
- define minimum national and regional focal point structure
- prepare model MoU templates
- engage with the African Humanitarian Coordination Platform.

Within 6 months

Priority actions in this window are as follows:

- launch focal point registration process
- hold first continental coordination meeting
- define regional forum arrangements with each REC
- issue initial partner engagement guidance
- map major continental humanitarian actors and coordination interfaces.

Within 12 months

Priority actions in this window are as follows:

- conclude priority MoUs with RECs and selected partners
- produce first annual continental coordination review
- revise framework implementation guidance based on lessons.

Milestones on simulations, roster development, Regional Centre capacity assessment, standby capacities, pooled relief arrangements and readiness standards should be implemented through Framework 4 and, where financing or in-kind resources are involved, Framework 2. The roadmap above reflects a managed-ambition sequence: AfHA first establishes the coordination architecture, the single entry point, the standing hub in its initial form, and the partner and focal-point relationships required for later operational expansion.

19. Relationship with SOPs to be developed

- Multi-level coordination
- Partner engagement
- Cross-border coordination and mutual support.

20. Conclusion

This Framework provides the relational architecture for AfHA. It clarifies that AfHA's strength will not come from acting alone, but from its ability to organise, align and strengthen the many institutions already present across Africa's humanitarian space. If implemented well, this framework will make AfHA the trusted continental coordinator and strategic humanitarian partner that Africa currently lacks, while preserving Member State primacy, strengthening REC engagement, and enabling more coherent partnerships with African and global actors alike.

The framework rests on a disciplined understanding of what AfHA is and what it is not. AfHA is the operational arm of the African Union Department of Health, Humanitarian Affairs and Social Development, not a parallel policy authority and not a standing implementing agency that displaces Member States, RECs or operational partners. Its value lies in convening, aligning, connecting and,

where genuine gaps exist, filling them. Every function and structure it assumes must first pass the complementarity test, which is the framework's principal safeguard against the duplication and mandate creep that have weakened comparable institutions elsewhere. Holding to this discipline is what will allow AfHA to earn, rather than assert, its place in the continental humanitarian architecture.

The framework also reflects a deliberate choice to learn from the accumulated practice of mature humanitarian coordination mechanisms while remaining firmly African in ownership and design. The provisions for a single operational entry point, a standing continental coordination hub, pre-agreed standby arrangements and pooled capacities, a certified and retained deployable roster, and a tiered and predictable suite of information products are not borrowed wholesale from any single external model. They are distilled from what has been shown to work across several regions and adapted to AfHA's Statute, to the realities of African financing and capacity, and to the primacy of Member States and RECs. Applied together, these provisions turn coordination from a series of meetings into a set of dependable services that partners and affected states can rely upon before, during and after a disaster.

Implementation will be phased and evidence-led. Recognising the financing, capacity and political constraints identified during consultation, AfHA will begin with a core set of coordination functions delivered through existing African Union presences and Regional Centres, and will expand its functional, geographic and operational scope only as predictable financing, demonstrated performance and Member State confidence allow. This managed-ambition sequence is not a limitation on AfHA's aspiration but the mechanism through which that aspiration becomes credible: early, visible and well-executed coordination builds the trust that unlocks the resources and political commitment needed for the agency to grow into its full mandate.

The framework is not self-executing. Its provisions must be carried into practice through the standard operating procedures identified in section 19, through the companion foundational frameworks on financing, data and information interoperability, capacity and surge readiness, preparedness and anticipatory action, and advocacy and visibility, and above all through the sustained engagement of Member States, RECs and partners. Coordination is ultimately a relationship rather than a structure, and the arrangements set out here will only deliver value if they are used, reviewed and improved through the accountability, simulation and peer-review mechanisms described in section 16.

In conclusion, this framework offers AfHA a clear, disciplined and politically feasible pathway to becoming the coordinating institution that Africa's humanitarian landscape requires: one that strengthens rather than supplants existing capacities, that keeps humanitarian coordination distinct from political bargaining, that includes local actors and affected populations rather than speaking only to high-level institutions, and that embodies African leadership in humanitarian action while remaining open to strategic support from the wider international system. Delivered with discipline and sustained commitment, it provides the relational foundation on which the remaining frameworks, and AfHA's operational credibility, can be built.